Identity as the Dynamic Center of Human Motivation

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Abstract

Human motivation is commonly explained in terms of needs, goals, rewards, values, or meaning. While these approaches have generated major insights, they often leave insufficiently clarified a prior question: how is motivational priority actually organized in concrete human action? We argue that human beings do not act directly from fixed needs alone, nor simply from externally specified goals, but from the need, value, fear, or project that becomes situationally primary in light of who they believe they are. On this view, identity is not a secondary layer added to motivation, but its dynamic organizing center.

We define identity broadly as the evolving organization of self-perception, personal history, aspiration, threatened selfhood, and projected future possibilities. This identity structure is shaped by the interaction of environment, developmental experience, cognitive capacity, and dispositional orientation. Because identity is dynamic rather than fixed, motivational organization must also be dynamic: what becomes primary in action changes as the self is reinterpreted, destabilized, reinforced, or reoriented over time.

On this basis, we propose a theory of **identity-mediated motivational prioritization**. The central claim is that human action tends to follow the need or aim that the individual's identity renders primary in a given situation. This framework helps explain why different individuals may respond very differently to similar circumstances, why the same person may radically reorganize priorities across life stages, and why many forms of action—such as sacrifice, vocation, self-transformation, withdrawal, or the pursuit of meaning—cannot be adequately reduced to immediate utility or static need hierarchies.

We further argue that a psychologically credible account of motivation must include unconscious opacity and irrational dynamics. Identity is not always fully transparent to itself; motivational life may be shaped by conflict, discrepancy, repression, self-deception, or even attraction to disorder, risk, and existential intensity. These elements do not undermine the model, but reveal that motivational organization is structured without being fully conscious, and dynamic without being arbitrary.

The paper concludes by suggesting that this framework has implications beyond classical motivational psychology. In particular, it sheds light on contemporary identity-shaping environments, such as social media, and suggests that any serious attempt to model human-like autonomy in artificial systems may require more than problem-solving and goal optimization alone: it may require a dynamically organized architecture of identity and motivational priority.

Keywords: identity; human motivation; motivational hierarchy; motivational prioritization; self-concept; narrative identity; possible selves; identity-based motivation; self-discrepancy; meaning; agency; theoretical psychology

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1. Introduction

Human motivation is most often discussed in terms of needs, goals, rewards, values, or meaning. This literature has produced major advances, from Maslow's classic attempt to theorize human motivation as an ordered structure of needs to Deci and Ryan's account of autonomy, competence, and relatedness as basic psychological needs shaping the quality of motivation. Yet these approaches still leave insufficiently clarified a prior question: **how is motivational priority actually organized in concrete human action?** In other words, why does one motive become primary while another remains secondary, even when both are psychologically available? (Maslow, 1943; Deci & Ryan, 2000).

We argue that this question cannot be fully answered by needs or goals alone. To understand action, psychology must also explain how the person organizes what matters. Our central claim is that human beings tend to act according to the need, value, fear, or project that becomes situationally primary in light of who they believe they are. This shifts the theoretical center of gravity from motivational contents taken in isolation to **identity** as the principle that orders motivational salience. This claim builds on several existing traditions: Erikson's view of identity as a psychosocial process, McAdams's account of identity as an evolving life story, Markus and Nurius's theory of possible selves, and Oyserman's identity-based motivation framework, which emphasizes that identities are dynamically constructed in context and shape action-readiness (Erikson, 1968; McAdams, 2001; Markus & Nurius, 1986; Oyserman, 2015).

In this paper, we use **identity** in a broad psychological sense. We do not mean only an explicit self-description or a socially recognized role. We mean the evolving organization of self-perception, personal history, aspiration, threatened selfhood, and projected future possibilities. This broader use is important because the self is not only retrospective but also projective: people act not only from who they think they are, but also from who they hope to become or fear becoming. Theories of possible selves and narrative identity are especially important here because they show that future-oriented self-representations are not peripheral fantasies; they are motivationally consequential structures within the self-concept itself (Markus & Nurius, 1986; McAdams, 2001).

An identity-centered account of motivation must also be socially and developmentally grounded. We do not encounter the world as abstract decision-makers with pre-specified priorities. Rather, our motivational organization emerges through lived environments, developmental history, and the meanings through which we interpret both. Lewin's field theory remains foundational because it frames behavior in relation to the person's psychological environment, or "life space," while Erikson makes clear that identity is formed not in isolation but at the intersection of individual development and communal culture. If identity is socially formed and historically sedimented, then motivational order cannot be treated as fixed, purely internal, or context-free (Lewin, 1951; Erikson, 1968).

On this basis, we propose a theory of **identity-mediated motivational prioritization**. The core idea is simple: needs do not govern action directly merely by existing; they become behaviorally decisive when identity renders them primary in a given situation. This perspective helps explain why individuals facing similar objective conditions may orient themselves toward very different actions, and why the same person may radically reorganize priorities across life stages, crises, attachments, or future commitments. It also helps explain forms of action that are not easily reducible to immediate utility, including sacrifice, vocation, existential redirection, and the search for meaning. Frankl's logotherapeutic tradition is especially relevant here because it treats meaning as a primary motivational force; our claim is that what becomes meaningful enough to organize action depends on the structure of identity through which the person interprets self, world, and future (Frankl, 1963).

The aim of this paper is therefore not to offer another list of human needs, nor to deny the relevance of goals, rewards, or values. It is to provide a structural account of how motivation becomes ordered in human beings. We first examine the limits of standard motivational approaches. We then develop an identity-centered framework in which action is guided by the need, value, fear, or aim that the self renders situationally primary. Finally, we show why such a framework must also account for unconscious opacity, self-discrepancy, and attraction to disorder, and we briefly consider its implications for identity-shaping environments such as social media and, more cautiously, for the problem of modeling human-like autonomy in artificial systems (Higgins, 1987; Oyserman, 2015; Zuckerman, 1979).

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2. Limits of Standard Approaches to Motivation

Psychology does not lack theories of motivation; rather, it lacks a sufficiently unified account of **how motivational priority is organized within the person**. Existing approaches illuminate important parts of the picture, but they often remain partially disconnected from one another. Need-based models explain recurring forms of human urgency. Reward- and goal-based models explain directionality and persistence. Identity-centered and meaning-centered approaches explain continuity, coherence, and existential orientation. Yet these traditions do not fully resolve a prior structural question: **why does one motive become primary, here and now, for this person rather than another?** We argue that this unresolved question marks the main theoretical gap to which the present paper responds.

2.1 Need-based approaches

Need-based theories remain foundational because they correctly reject the idea that human action is motivationally flat. Maslow's classic account of a hierarchy of needs is the most influential expression of this insight: human motivation is structured, and different forms of need are not equally primary under all conditions (Maslow, 1943). This remains a major achievement, because it recognizes that behavior is patterned by recurrent forms of urgency rather than by random preference.

At the same time, classical need theory leaves open an important issue. Even if needs can be ordered in general terms, it does not necessarily follow that their practical ordering is fixed in concrete life. Individuals living under similar objective conditions may still assign radically

different psychological priority to security, recognition, attachment, meaning, autonomy, or withdrawal. In other words, the existence of needs does not by itself explain their **situational hierarchy**. Need theory tells us that human beings are structured; it does not fully explain how this structure becomes individualized in action.

2.2 Reward-, goal-, and basic-needs models

A second major tradition explains motivation through reward, goal pursuit, or the regulation of behavior toward desired ends. Within contemporary psychology, Self-Determination Theory represents one of the most important and sophisticated versions of this broader family. Deci and Ryan argue that autonomy, competence, and relatedness are basic psychological needs, and that the quality of motivation depends on the extent to which these needs are supported or thwarted by the social environment (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000). This is an important step beyond simpler behaviorist or externally driven accounts, because it brings subjectivity and context back into motivational theory.

However, even these models tend to begin from motivational contents that are already identifiable. The person seeks competence, autonomy, recognition, belonging, achievement, or some explicit goal. What remains less clearly theorized is how one of these orientations becomes existentially central while others remain secondary. A person may value many things at once, yet only some of them become decisive for action. We therefore suggest that goals and needs, while indispensable, are not sufficient as ultimate explanatory units. Their motivational force depends on a prior ordering process within the self.

2.3 Identity-centered approaches

Identity-based approaches move much closer to the problem addressed in this paper. Erikson's work made identity a central developmental and psychosocial achievement rather than a peripheral feature of personality (Erikson, 1968). McAdams later deepened this perspective by describing identity as an evolving narrative through which people organize the remembered past and imagined future into a relatively coherent life story (McAdams, 2001). Markus and Nurius added a crucial future-oriented dimension with their concept of **possible selves**, showing that people are motivated not only by who they are, but by who they might become, hope to become, or fear becoming (Markus & Nurius, 1986).

These traditions are essential for our argument because they show that selfhood is not motivationally neutral. People do not simply possess goals; they interpret those goals through developmental self-understandings, narrative trajectories, and projected futures. More recent work on identity-based motivation makes this link even clearer by arguing that identities are dynamically constructed in context and that individuals are more ready to act when a course of action feels congruent with who they are (Oyserman, 2009, 2015).

Yet even here, an important step often remains implicit. Identity is usually treated as a background condition for motivation, a source of coherence, or a moderator of behavior. It is less often treated as the **operative principle that selects which need, value, or aim becomes primary in a given situation**. This is the step we want to make explicit.

2.4 Meaning-centered approaches

Meaning-centered theories provide another important resource. Frankl argued that human beings are not guided only by pleasure or power, but also by the search for meaning, and that this search may become decisive even under conditions of suffering and deprivation (Frankl, 1963). This tradition is especially valuable because it helps explain forms of action that are difficult to reduce to immediate utility: sacrifice, vocation, endurance, existential redirection, and loyalty to a cause.

Nevertheless, meaning-centered theories do not fully specify how meaning becomes motivationally dominant within the broader structure of the self. Meaning is rightly treated as powerful, but its organization often remains underdescribed. Why does one person organize life around achievement, another around belonging, another around moral repair, and another around rupture or withdrawal? We suggest that meaning does not become primary in the abstract. It becomes primary when it is incorporated into the person's identity as central, necessary, redemptive, or impossible to betray.

2.5 The unresolved gap

Taken together, these traditions show that motivation is structured, context-sensitive, developmental, and often future-oriented. But they do not yet provide a sufficiently explicit model of **how motivational hierarchy is generated within the person**. Need theories tell us that human beings are not motivationally uniform. Basic-needs and goal theories show that motivation varies in quality and context. Identity theories show that selfhood is developmental and future-oriented. Meaning-centered theories show that action may be organized by significance rather than utility. What remains insufficiently articulated is the mechanism by which these elements are ordered in concrete action.

This is the theoretical gap addressed by the present paper. We do not deny that people seek security, attachment, competence, esteem, autonomy, or meaning. We argue instead that these become behaviorally decisive only through an identity structure that ranks them in context. Put differently, **motivation is not organized by needs alone, but by the way identity renders some needs, values, fears, and aims situationally primary**. The next section develops this claim directly by proposing identity as the dynamic center of human motivation.

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3. Identity as the Dynamic Center of Motivation

We propose that the most appropriate theoretical center for a structural account of human motivation is **identity**. By identity, we do not mean a simple self-label, a declared role, or a static cluster of traits. We mean the evolving organization through which a person understands who they are, who they have been, who they may become, and what kinds of futures appear desirable, threatening, tolerable, or impossible to inhabit. This use is consistent with Erikson's view of identity as a psychosocial formation shaped through development, with McAdams's account of identity as an internalized and evolving life story, and with Markus and Nurius's theory of possible selves, which places hoped-for and feared futures inside the motivational structure of the self (Erikson, 1968; McAdams, 2001; Markus & Nurius, 1986).

3.1 Identity is not a static self-description

A central claim of this paper is that identity must be treated as an **organizing structure**, not as a descriptive appendix to motivation. In much of psychology, identity explains continuity, self-understanding, and developmental coherence. We retain those insights, but extend them: identity is not only what gives a person a sense of sameness over time; it is also what orders relevance within action. McAdams's life-story approach is especially important here, because it frames identity as an internalized narrative that reconstructs the past and imagines the future in ways that provide unity, purpose, and meaning. Once identity is understood in that way, it cannot remain motivationally neutral (McAdams, 2001).

For this reason, we define identity in a broad psychological sense. It includes at least three interrelated dimensions: **perceived identity** (who one takes oneself to be), **aspirational identity** (who one wants to become), and **aversive or threatened identity** (what one fears becoming, rejects, or experiences as incompatible with the self). Markus and Nurius are decisive on this point, because possible selves include goals, aspirations, motives, fears, and threats; they function as incentives for future behavior and mediate personal functioning. Identity, in this broader sense, is therefore already linked to motivation before any concrete action is selected (Markus & Nurius, 1986).

3.2 Identity is formed in environment and history

If identity is the center of motivational organization, it cannot be understood apart from the environments in which it is formed. Lewin remains fundamental here because field theory treats behavior in relation to the person's psychological environment, or life space, rather than as a simple response to isolated stimuli. What matters is not only the objective situation, but the way that situation is lived, structured, and integrated by the person. Identity, on this view, does not emerge in abstraction; it emerges in relation to family structure, social expectations, institutional settings, cultural meanings, opportunities, exclusions, and lived constraints (Lewin, 1951).

Erikson strengthens this point by showing that identity is psychosocial in nature. It is not a merely private construct, but a developmental achievement formed through the interaction of individual capacities and social worlds. From our perspective, this means that motivational order cannot be grounded in needs alone, because the ordering of priorities depends on an identity already shaped by developmental history. A person's practical hierarchy is therefore neither purely internal nor simply chosen in the present; it is historically sedimented and socially mediated (Erikson, 1968; Lewin, 1951).

3.3 Identity is future-oriented as well as retrospective

We also argue that identity is intrinsically **projective**. Human beings do not act only from who they think they already are; they also act from who they are trying to become, trying to avoid becoming, or trying to recover. This is where possible selves become indispensable. Markus and Nurius explicitly frame possible selves as future-oriented components of self-concept that function as incentives for behavior. That claim is crucial for the present paper because it shows that motivation is not exhausted by present deprivation or immediate reward. It is also organized by imagined futures incorporated into identity itself (Markus & Nurius, 1986).

This future-oriented dimension helps explain why people may endure present discomfort for a professional identity not yet attained, leave a stable life to escape an intolerable self-image, or pursue difficult transformations whose immediate utility is unclear. These are not anomalies once identity is treated as motivationally generative. They are precisely what we should expect if action is partly organized by selfhood under construction. McAdams's account supports this point because narrative identity integrates remembered past and imagined future into a relatively coherent sense of self in time (McAdams, 2001).

3.4 Identity organizes motivational salience

The crucial theoretical step is this: identity does not merely accompany motivation; it **organizes motivational salience**. We therefore reject the idea that needs act directly on behavior in an unmediated way. Human beings may have many needs, values, fears, and goals available at once, but these do not all become equally urgent in a given situation. What becomes primary depends on the person's identity structure. We may formulate this as the central principle of the paper:

Principle of Identity-Mediated Priority
In any given situation, the motivational priority of needs, values, fears, or goals is determined by the individual's dynamic identity structure.

This claim is close in spirit to Oyserman's identity-based motivation theory, which argues that identities are dynamically constructed in context, influence action when they come to mind, and matter when action feels congruent with identity in the moment. We go one step further by making prioritization itself the center of the argument: identity does not simply make action feel reasonable; it orders what becomes motivationally primary (Oyserman, 2009, 2015).

3.5 Identity and action

From this follows the paper's main proposition: **human beings tend to act in accordance with the need, value, fear, or project that their identity renders situationally primary**. We formulate this as a tendency rather than a strict law, because later sections will address unconscious opacity and irrational dynamics. Still, as a structural principle, it explains a wide range of behaviors more effectively than models based only on utility, reward, or generic need satisfaction. It explains why two people in similar objective conditions may choose incompatible courses of action, why one person may reorganize an entire life around a new aspiration, and why some actions remain coherent from within even when they appear anti-utilitarian from the outside. Oyserman's emphasis on action-readiness is particularly useful here, because it shows that identity is not merely contemplative; it is behaviorally activating when a course of action feels self-relevant in context (Oyserman, 2009, 2015).

Frankl's meaning-centered psychology also helps clarify the point. His major insight is that human beings may be guided not only by pleasure or power, but by meaning. We retain that insight, but place it inside a broader structural account: what becomes meaningful enough to orient action depends on identity. Meaning does not float free; it becomes motivationally decisive when it is integrated into the person's self-organization as central, necessary, redemptive, or impossible to betray (Frankl, 1963).

3.6 Transition

If identity is indeed the dynamic center of motivation, the next theoretical task is to specify **how** identity transforms a plurality of needs, values, fears, and aims into a hierarchy of practical urgency. The following section develops that claim directly by showing that motivation should be understood not as a fixed hierarchy, but as a process of **identity-mediated motivational prioritization**.

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4. Identity-Mediated Motivational Prioritization

If identity is the dynamic center of motivation, the next question is not whether identity matters, but **how** it matters. We argue that identity does not directly produce action in a simple or mechanical sense. Rather, it organizes **motivational priority**. At any given moment, a person may be responsive to many possible demands at once: security, recognition, attachment, autonomy, competence, meaning, escape, repair, or transformation. These demands do not all enter action with equal force. What identity does is rank them. It determines which need, value, fear, or project becomes **situationally primary**, and it is this prioritization that guides action. In this sense, the central mechanism of the paper is not identity alone, but **identity-mediated motivational prioritization** (Markus & Nurius, 1986; Oyserman, 2009, 2015).

4.1 From multiplicity to priority

A psychologically realistic account of action must begin from the fact that human beings are motivationally plural. People do not possess one motive at a time; they inhabit a field of partially competing demands. Need-based theories identify recurring classes of these demands, while Self-Determination Theory shows that autonomy, competence, and relatedness are basic psychological needs whose support or frustration affects the quality of motivation (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000). Yet even within such frameworks, a further question remains: **why does one motive become decisive in this situation for this person?**

Our answer is that motives do not become behaviorally decisive simply by existing. They become decisive when identity renders them primary. The person does not act directly from "need" in the abstract, but from the need as ordered within a lived self. This allows us to state the central principle of the paper more precisely:

Principle of Identity-Mediated Priority
In any given situation, the motivational priority of needs, values, fears, and goals is determined by the individual's dynamic identity structure.

This principle does not deny needs. It explains how they become operative.

4.2 Situational primacy

Motivational hierarchy, on our account, is not fixed once and for all. It is **situationally organized**. The same person may rank motives differently across different circumstances, and different persons may rank motives differently within the same circumstance. Lewin's field-theoretical perspective remains useful here because it reminds us that behavior emerges within a life space, not in relation to an abstract world stripped of subjective meaning (Lewin, 1951). A situation is never merely external; it is interpreted through identity.

This is why the same event may function very differently across persons. A promotion may be experienced as recognition by one individual, exposure by another, betrayal by a third, and liberation by a fourth. The objective event is identical, but its motivational meaning is not. What changes is not simply preference; what changes is the identity through which the situation is encountered. Once this is granted, situational priority can no longer be treated as a trivial derivative of fixed needs. It must be understood as identity-mediated.

4.3 Goals do not have equal motivational status

This framework also clarifies the status of goals. In much motivational psychology, goals are treated as desired end states represented in cognition. That is useful, but insufficient. Not all goals have the same psychological weight. Some remain preferences, others become organizing commitments, and still others function as defensive formations, compensations, or imagined exits. Self-Determination Theory already improves on simpler models by distinguishing forms of motivation that differ in quality and degree of integration (Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000). We accept that insight, but add that the decisive issue is not only whether a goal is internalized, but **how it is positioned within identity**.

A person may endorse the same nominal goal for very different reasons. A professional career may be pursued as self-realization, social validation, moral duty, escape from shame, continuity with family identity, or protection against a feared future self. Externally, the goal looks the same. Structurally, it is not the same goal at all, because its motivational force depends on the identity architecture in which it is embedded. This is why explicit goal statements are insufficient predictors of action unless we also understand what the goal means within the self.

4.4 Meaning as a special case of motivational priority

Frankl's work is especially valuable at this point because it shows that human beings may be guided by meaning rather than by immediate pleasure or advantage (Frankl, 1963). We agree, but we treat meaning not as an independent motivational realm floating above the rest of psychology. We treat it as a particularly powerful form of identity-mediated priority. What becomes meaningful enough to govern action depends on the self's organization of past, present, and future.

This helps explain why people sometimes endure suffering, uncertainty, or material loss for aims that appear irrational from the standpoint of immediate utility. Meaningful action is not simply action aimed at "importance" in some abstract sense. It is action organized around what the person experiences as central to who they are, who they must become, or what they cannot betray without self-loss. In this sense, meaning does not replace motivation; it intensifies and stabilizes motivational priority through identity.

4.5 Dynamic reordering

Because identity is dynamic, motivational priority must also be dynamic. This is one of the major consequences of the present framework. Eriksonian development, narrative identity theory, and possible-selves research all imply that selfhood changes across time through experience, reinterpretation, aspiration, loss, and social embedding (Erikson, 1968; McAdams, 2001; Markus & Nurius, 1986). If identity changes, then the ordering of motives changes with it.

This means that motivational life cannot be adequately captured either by a rigid universal hierarchy or by a purely momentary model of preference. It is neither timeless nor random. It is historically shaped, situationally activated, and dynamically reordered. What once felt central may become secondary; what once seemed impossible may become necessary; what once organized action may later be experienced as alien. A psychologically adequate theory of motivation must therefore explain not only stability of priority, but also its transformation.

4.6 Action as the outcome of prioritized identity

We can now state the paper's main operational claim in its most compact form: **human beings tend to act in accordance with the need, value, fear, or project that their identity renders situationally primary**. This formulation is preferable to the simpler claim that people "act from identity," because it identifies the mediating mechanism. Identity matters because it orders salience. It selects urgency. It confers centrality.

This also helps us avoid two theoretical mistakes. On the one hand, we avoid reducing action to bare need. On the other hand, we avoid treating identity as a purely narrative or reflective construct detached from behavior. Identity is behaviorally consequential because it structures motivational priority. That is the mechanism through which it enters action.

4.7 Transition

The model is now sufficiently specified at the structural level: human beings act neither from needs alone nor from identity in the abstract, but from the motive that identity renders primary in a given situation. Yet one major complication remains. Identity is not always transparent to itself, and motivational priority is not always consciously accessible or orderly. To make the framework psychologically credible, we must therefore examine the role of unconscious processes, internal discrepancy, and irrational dynamics in the organization of action.

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5. Unconscious Processes and Irrational Dynamics

The model developed so far would remain incomplete if identity were treated as fully transparent to itself. We do not assume that human beings always know, at the moment of action, why a given need, value, fear, or project has become primary. Nor do we assume that identity is exhausted by explicit self-description. A psychologically credible account of motivation must therefore include **opacity**, **conflict**, and **distortion** within the self. This is not an optional complication added at the margins of an otherwise orderly model; it is part of what makes motivational life specifically human. In this respect, psychoanalytic theory remains historically important because it established, in a lasting way, that mental processes outside conscious awareness may shape behavior and self-understanding (Freud, 1915/1957).

5.1 The opacity of identity

If identity is the dynamic center of motivation, it does not follow that identity is fully conscious. A person's self-understanding may be partial, selective, defensive, or internally inconsistent. What a person says they want, what they consciously endorse, and what actually organizes their action may

diverge. This is one reason why a purely declarative theory of motivation is insufficient. The self is not always immediately available to itself.

This point matters because motivational priority may be structured by elements of identity that are only partially accessible. A person may pursue recognition while consciously describing the pursuit as duty, seek escape while narrating it as independence, or organize an entire life around a feared self they cannot clearly name. In such cases, action remains identity-mediated, but the relevant identity structure is not fully available to introspection. We therefore retain a minimal but crucial psychoanalytic insight: the self can be motivationally effective without being fully self-present (Freud, 1915/1957).

5.2 Internal discrepancy and conflict

Opacity is not the only complication. Identity may also be internally divided. Higgins's self-discrepancy theory is especially useful here because it shows that motivation is often shaped not only by who a person takes themselves to be, but by the gap between the **actual self**, the **ideal self**, and the **ought self** (Higgins, 1987). Such discrepancies generate tension, shame, guilt, aspiration, avoidance, and compensatory striving.

For the present framework, the importance of self-discrepancy is structural. Identity does not organize motivation only through stable self-coherence; it may also organize it through internal tension. The motive that becomes primary in a situation may arise from discrepancy rather than harmony: the need to repair oneself, prove oneself, hide oneself, redeem oneself, or avoid becoming a feared version of oneself. This allows us to preserve the identity-centered account without idealizing identity as unified or serene. Identity may be fractured and still remain motivationally central.

5.3 Irrationality as malfunction

Once opacity and discrepancy are admitted, we can distinguish two forms of irrationality. The first is irrationality as **malfunction**. Here we refer to cases in which action no longer tracks the person's broader identity organization in any stable or intelligible way. Severe impulsivity, cognitive collapse under stress, pathological fixation, or forms of conduct marked by profound disorganization belong to this category. In such cases, behavior may still be motivated, but the system that ordinarily orders motivational priority is impaired, weakened, or distorted.

This distinction is important because our theory is not meant to imply that all action is rational in any classical sense. To say that action is identity-mediated is not to say that it is transparent, optimal, or well integrated. It means only that, under ordinary conditions, motivational life is structured through the self more deeply than through isolated need or utility alone. Malfunction names a disruption of that ordinary structuring process.

5.4 Irrationality as attraction to disorder

The second form is more theoretically interesting: irrationality not as breakdown, but as **attraction to disorder, intensity, or rupture**. Some actions are not best interpreted as errors or pathologies. They may express a deliberate search for chaos, risk, excess, provocation, or escape from psychic flatness. Here Zuckerman becomes relevant. His work on sensation seeking shows that the pursuit

of novelty, intensity, and risk is not merely an accidental deviation from ordinary motivation; it may reflect a stable dispositional orientation (Zuckerman, 1979).

This matters for our framework because it shows that not every departure from stability is a failure of regulation. For some individuals, excessive order, predictability, or closure may itself become motivationally intolerable. In such cases, disorder acquires identity-value. Risk, disruption, provocation, or transgression may become primary not because the person has lost all organization, but because such experiences are integrated into who they take themselves to be. Here the motivationally primary aim may not be safety or coherence, but intensity, expansion, anti-flatness, or escape from an experienced deadness of life.

5.5 Why these complications do not weaken the model

At first glance, unconscious processes and irrational dynamics might seem to threaten the entire framework. If people do not know themselves clearly, and if they may act in disordered ways, why retain identity as the center of motivation at all? We argue that these complications do not weaken the model; they make it realistic. A theory that explains action only when the self is transparent, orderly, and self-consistent would fail precisely where psychology becomes most interesting.

This is why we speak of a **dynamic identity structure** rather than a fixed self-concept. Identity includes explicit self-understanding, internal discrepancy, feared selves, aspirational selves, and partially inaccessible motives. What becomes primary in action may therefore reflect coherence, compensation, defense, avoidance, repair, or self-intensification. The person still acts through an organized motivational field, but that field is not always peaceful or conscious.

5.6 Transition

We are now in a position to restate the central thesis in a more complete form. Human beings tend to act in accordance with the need, value, fear, or project that their identity renders situationally primary, but identity itself may be opaque, internally discrepant, or drawn toward disorder as well as coherence. This broader formulation fits the realities of human behavior better than either a fixed hierarchy of needs or a purely rational model of motivation. The next section draws together the framework's main implications, including its relevance to identity-shaping environments such as social media and, more cautiously, to the problem of modeling human-like autonomy in artificial systems.

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6. Discussion

The framework developed in this paper proposes that human motivation is best understood not as the direct expression of fixed needs, nor as the execution of pre-specified goals, but as the outcome of **identity-mediated motivational prioritization**. In this view, what matters most for action is not only what a person needs, values, or fears in the abstract, but which of these becomes primary in light of who that person believes they are. This claim does not reject existing traditions in motivational psychology. Rather, it seeks to reorganize them around a more explicit structural question: how, in a concrete person, does motivational order arise? In this respect, our framework draws on need-based theories, basic psychological needs, psychosocial identity development, narrative identity, possible selves, and meaning-centered motivation, but argues that these lines of

work are most fully integrated when identity is treated as the principle that orders practical salience (Maslow, 1943; Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000; Erikson, 1968; McAdams, 2001; Markus & Nurius, 1986; Frankl, 1963).

6.1 What this framework explains

One advantage of this framework is that it explains why similar situations can yield very different actions without treating those differences as noise. Need-based theories correctly identify recurrent forms of human urgency, and Self-Determination Theory rightly emphasizes autonomy, competence, and relatedness as basic psychological needs. Yet neither approach, on its own, fully explains why one of these, or some other motive, becomes dominant for a particular person in a particular moment. By making identity the ordering principle, we can explain why the same objective circumstance may be experienced as challenge, confirmation, threat, temptation, duty, escape, or vocation.

The framework also explains why future-oriented and biographical elements matter so much to present action. Possible-selves research shows that hoped-for and feared futures function as incentives for behavior, while narrative identity theory shows that the self is organized across time through the integration of remembered past and anticipated future (Markus & Nurius, 1986; McAdams, 2001). Our contribution is to state more directly what follows from this convergence: identity does not merely contextualize motivation; it **selects motivational priority**.

A further strength of the model is that it can account for anti-utilitarian or apparently non-maximizing behavior without treating it as theoretically marginal. Frankl's emphasis on meaning is especially important here. People do not simply pursue immediate benefit in the abstract; they often act in ways that fit who they take themselves to be, or who they experience themselves as becoming. Sacrifice, vocation, persistence under uncertainty, and existential redirection become far more intelligible once we recognize that motivational hierarchy is organized through identity rather than through utility alone (Frankl, 1963).

6.2 Relation to existing psychology

We therefore do not present this framework as a rejection of mainstream motivational psychology. Maslow remains important because he recognized that motivation is structured rather than flat, and Self-Determination Theory remains indispensable because it clarifies how social conditions support or thwart high-quality motivation through autonomy, competence, and relatedness (Maslow, 1943; Deci & Ryan, 2000; Ryan & Deci, 2000). What we question is the tendency to stop at needs themselves, as though their practical ordering were self-explanatory. Our argument is that needs become behaviorally decisive only through an identity structure that ranks them in context.

This also clarifies the relation between our model and identity-based approaches. Eriksonian and narrative theories convincingly show that selfhood is developmental, social, and temporally extended, while possible-selves theory shows that hoped-for and feared futures are motivationally potent (Erikson, 1968; McAdams, 2001; Markus & Nurius, 1986). Identity-based motivation theory adds the important claim that identities are dynamically constructed in context and shape action-readiness when they feel relevant in the moment (Oyserman, 2009, 2015). Our framework is consistent with these approaches, but places stronger emphasis on one point: the hierarchy of action is not merely accompanied by identity; it is **organized through identity**.

The model also benefits from the complications introduced in the previous section. Because identity may be opaque, internally discrepant, or drawn toward disorder, motivational priority cannot be equated with conscious endorsement. This makes the framework more psychologically realistic. A person may act from a feared self, from unresolved discrepancy, or from an identity investment not yet fully available to reflection. In that sense, identity-mediated prioritization is not a theory of transparent self-knowledge. It is a theory of how the self, even when conflicted or partly hidden, organizes what becomes urgent (Freud, 1915/1957; Higgins, 1987).

6.3 Identity-shaping environments: the case of social media

One major implication of this framework concerns environments that do not merely constrain behavior, but actively shape identity. Social media platforms are especially important here. Recent literature suggests that social media function as a significant context for adolescent identity development and that the **quality** of engagement matters more than sheer time spent online. A recent systematic review found that active participation was associated more strongly with identity exploration, authentic self-presentation with greater self-concept clarity, and social comparison with greater identity distress (Avci et al., 2025).

This is highly relevant to our framework. If identity organizes motivational salience, then environments that stabilize, amplify, reward, or distort particular self-representations may reorganize motivation at its source. The point is not simply that social media influence opinions or preferences. The stronger claim is that they may shape the self through repeated comparison, curated self-presentation, quantifiable feedback, and algorithmically filtered exposure. The same review suggests that digital environments can both support and destabilize identity formation, depending on how they are used (Avci et al., 2025).

The broader evidence base supports a non-simplistic reading of this issue. The APA's advisory on adolescent social media use emphasizes that effects are not uniformly beneficial or harmful, but depend on the characteristics of the adolescent, the social context, and the design and functions of the platforms involved (American Psychological Association, 2023). An umbrella review likewise concluded that social media use entails both risks and opportunities for adolescent mental health and well-being, with outcomes varying by usage type, personal factors, and platform design (Sala et al., 2024).

For our purposes, then, social media should not be treated merely as communication tools. They are **identity-shaping environments**. They can support exploration, recognition, and belonging, but they can also externally stabilize identities that are comparative, idealized, polarized, or dependency-forming. If motivation is organized through identity, then the manipulation of identity becomes a deeper form of motivational influence than the simple triggering of desire.

6.4 Possible implications for AGI research

Although the present paper is grounded in human psychology, the framework may also have cautious implications for research on artificial general intelligence. Many models of artificial agency are built around problem-solving, planning, reward optimization, or goal-directed performance. Such architectures may be sufficient for many forms of instrumental intelligence. However, if human-like motivation is organized not by fixed goals alone but by a dynamic identity

structure that reorders priorities across contexts, then models of general agency based exclusively on optimization may be structurally incomplete.

We do not suggest that an artificial system must literally possess human identity in order to act intelligently. The narrower point is theoretical: **human-like autonomy may require more than intelligence and goal pursuit alone**. It may also require a self-organizing architecture capable of stabilizing, revising, and hierarchizing motives in relation to an evolving self-model. In that sense, the psychology of identity may matter not only for understanding human action, but also for clarifying what current models of artificial agency still omit when they equate intelligence with optimization.

6.5 Scope and future research

This paper is theoretical, and its claims should therefore be read as an organizing framework rather than as a completed empirical program. Several lines of future work follow directly from it. First, identity-mediated prioritization should be operationalized more precisely: research could examine how perceived identity, aspirational identity, and feared identity differentially predict which motives become primary in specific contexts. Second, the model invites longitudinal work, because its core claim is developmental and dynamic rather than static. Third, identity-shaping environments, especially digital ones, should be studied not only in terms of outcomes such as well-being or distress, but in terms of how they alter self-concept clarity, identity commitment, identity distress, and the structure of motivational priority itself. Recent reviews explicitly note the need for more longitudinal and conceptually integrated work on these questions (Avci et al., 2025).

Overall, the discussion supports a simple conclusion: psychology can describe needs, goals, values, and meaning with increasing precision, but it still needs a clearer account of **how they are ordered within the person**. We have argued that identity is the missing center of that ordering. Once identity is treated as dynamic, socially formed, future-oriented, and partly opaque, motivation itself can be understood as a field of priorities rather than as a list of drives.

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7. Conclusion

We have argued that human motivation is not best understood as the direct expression of fixed needs, nor as the mere pursuit of rewards, goals, or utilities. Instead, motivation is organized through **identity-mediated prioritization**: people tend to act according to the need, value, fear, or project that becomes situationally primary in light of who they believe they are. This claim does not discard existing traditions in motivational psychology. Rather, it reorders them around a more explicit structural question: how does a person's motivational hierarchy arise in concrete action? In this sense, the present framework draws on need theory, psychosocial identity theory, narrative identity, possible selves, and meaning-centered psychology, while arguing that their strongest point of convergence lies in the organizing role of identity (Maslow, 1943; Erikson, 1968; Markus & Nurius, 1986; McAdams, 2001; Frankl, 1963).

The main contribution of the paper is therefore structural rather than taxonomic. We have not proposed a new list of human needs, nor a revised hierarchy in the classical sense. We have proposed that motivational order depends on the self: on the person's perceived identity, aspirational

identity, threatened identity, developmental history, and socially embedded life trajectory. In this framework, identity is not a secondary layer placed on top of motivation; it is the dynamic center through which motivational relevance is selected, ranked, and stabilized. This view is also compatible with more recent work showing that identities are dynamically constructed in context and shape action-readiness when they feel self-congruent in the moment (Oyserman, 2009, 2015).

We have also argued that this model becomes more psychologically credible, not less, once unconscious opacity and irrational dynamics are included. Human beings do not always know why a given motive has become primary; nor do they always seek order, stability, or optimization. Identity may be conflicted, partially hidden, discrepancy-driven, or drawn toward disorder and intensity as well as coherence. Yet these complications do not invalidate the framework. They show that motivational life is structured without being fully transparent, and dynamic without being arbitrary (Freud, 1915/1957; Higgins, 1987; Zuckerman, 1979).

Finally, we have suggested that the framework has implications beyond classical motivational psychology. In contemporary digital environments, where self-representations may be amplified, rewarded, distorted, and stabilized through external systems of feedback, the shaping of identity may become a deeper form of motivational influence than the simple triggering of desire. And at a more speculative level, if human-like autonomy depends on a dynamic architecture of identity and motivational priority, then models of artificial agency based exclusively on problem-solving and optimization may remain structurally incomplete. These implications do not alter the paper's psychological center, but they reinforce its broader claim: to understand human action, psychology must ask not only what people need, but **who they believe themselves to be**.

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